

1. Project Name

Odhikar (অধিকার — "rights") — AI Paralegal for Legal Aid Clients

2. Project Owner

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3. Problem Statement

BRAC runs the largest NGO-led legal aid programme in the world — a national network of legal aid clinics where paralegals resolve family, dowry, land and wage disputes, mostly through mediation rather than litigation. Two gaps limit it:

- **Clinics are oversubscribed, and intake eats the day.** Much of every first consultation goes to eliciting facts from a distressed client, working out which area of law applies, explaining basics, and writing it all down. None of that needs legal judgment — but it consumes the hours of the people who have it.
- **Most people who need help never arrive.** They don't know the law recognises their situation (a woman owed her dower often doesn't know it's an enforceable debt). They can't navigate forms and notices. They assume the process is too expensive or too intimidating for them.
- **Existing digital services don't close the gap.** The national helpline (16430) and legal aid app are real and useful, but they reproduce a text-first, operator-dependent model. Neither is built for a low-literacy user speaking Bangla, and neither produces a structured case record that flows into a clinic's intake.

The core issue: paralegal judgment is the scarce resource, and it is being spent on transcription — while the people who most need the service never reach the door.

4. Proposed Solution

A Bangla-language conversational AI service that lets someone describe a legal problem in their own words and prepares their case before they reach a clinic.

The flow:

1. **Speak, don't type.** The user describes what happened by voice in everyday Bangla — no forms, no reading required. A text path exists as fallback.
2. **The system understands a messy narrative.** Real people speak like this:

চার বছর আগে আমার বিয়ে হয়েছে। বিয়ের পর থেকে ওরা আমার বাবার কাছে টাকা চাইতে থাকে... কবিনের টাকা আজও পাইনি।

No dates, no amounts, no legal vocabulary, events out of order. The system extracts what it can and asks follow-up questions for the rest.

3. **Classify and explain.** It identifies the legal category and explains, in plain spoken Bangla, what the law recognises and what routes exist (mediation, formal complaint, clinic consultation).
4. **Generate the case record.** A structured summary — parties, chronology, claimed harm, amounts, evidence mentioned — plus a draft first complaint from a reviewed template.
5. **Refer to a clinic.** Nearest clinic, appointment slot, case summary already attached for the paralegal.

The boundary is a design requirement, not a disclaimer. Odhikar *informs and prepares*; it does not advise. Every generated document is a draft marked for paralegal review. Any disclosure of ongoing violence or immediate danger breaks the automated flow and routes to a human.

Explicitly out of scope — these will not earn credit and introduce real risk:

Out of scope	Why
Predicting case outcomes or likelihood of success	This is legal advice — professionally and ethically off-limits
Recommending whether to settle, litigate or drop	Same
Case-law retrieval or citing judgments	High hallucination risk, unverifiable in a week, unnecessary for intake

Out of scope	Why
Filing with any court, police station or government system	No authorisation, no integration, no supervision
Real HRLS/NLASO data or live client records	No data access; using real client data would be a serious breach
Languages other than Bangla; native mobile apps	The target user wouldn't use an English interface; web is the fastest path

5. Target Users

Primary — the client. Rural or peri-urban, limited formal schooling, basic or shared Android handset, comfortable with voice notes but not typing Bangla. Overwhelmingly women. Has a problem she suspects is wrong but doesn't know is *actionable*. *Implications:* voice first, no reading at any step, tolerant of long emotional non-linear narratives, works on a weak connection.

Secondary — the paralegal. Skilled at mediation and at reading local family dynamics; currently spends much of the day taking down facts. Needs the story structured and legible before the client sits down. *Implications:* editable summary, never authoritative, uncertain fields clearly flagged.

Tertiary — the clinic coordinator. Needs a queue of incoming referrals with category, urgency flag and escalation status visible at a glance.

6. Key Features

Priorities: **M** = must have (required to call the project done), **S** = should have, **C** = could have if time allows.

#	Feature	Priority
1	Bangla voice intake, with text fallback	M
2	Follow-up questioning to fill gaps (dates, parties, amounts)	M
3	Classification: dower & maintenance, dowry, land dispute, unpaid wages	M
4	Confidence handling — ask a disambiguating question rather than guess	M
5	"Outside our scope, here's who to contact" for unsupported matters	M
6	Plain-language rights and options explanation, spoken in Bangla	M
7	Structured case summary, with inferred fields marked as inferred	M
8	Draft first complaint from reviewed per-category templates	M
9	Safety detection with immediate human escalation	M
10	Clinic lookup and referral with case summary attached	M
11	Paralegal dashboard: incoming queue with urgency flags	S
12	Client's own words preserved alongside the structured version	S
13	Appointment booking from seeded availability	S
14	PDF export of the complaint draft	S
15	Session resume; SMS/voice confirmation; explanation replay	C

7. AI Component

Where AI does the work:

Capability	What it does
Speech recognition (Bangla)	Transcribes conversational, accented speech — the feature that makes the whole thing accessible
Language model — extraction	Pulls structured facts (parties, dates, amounts, chronology) out of a rambling non-linear narrative. This is the hard part and the real technical contribution
Language model — classification	Maps the situation to a legal category, with confidence, asking a disambiguating question rather than guessing
	Decides which follow-up question to ask next based on what's still missing

Capability	What it does
Language model — dialogue	
Safety classification	Detects disclosures of ongoing violence or danger, tuned to over-trigger rather than under-trigger
Text to speech (Bangla)	Speaks the response back

Where AI deliberately does *not* work: the legal language itself. Explanations and complaint drafts come from reviewed templates, not free generation. The model *understands*; templates *speak*. This hybrid pattern cuts the hallucination surface dramatically and is what makes the output defensible in a domain where a confident wrong answer causes real harm.

8. Expected Outcome / Impact

- **Paralegal time shifts from transcription to judgment.** A client arriving with a structured summary already prepared means the meeting starts at the work that needs expertise.
- **People find out they have a case.** The awareness gap is the bigger number — a voice-first Bangla service reaches people that forms and helplines don't.
- **Better first consultations.** Structured intake surfaces facts and evidence the client might not think to mention, and flags urgent cases before they wait in a queue.
- **A pattern that generalises.** Voice-first Bangla intake for low-literacy users applies to microfinance, health and social services well beyond legal aid.
- **Beyond the sprint:** IVR delivery so it works on any handset without internet; more dispute categories; real clinic scheduling integration; anonymised aggregate reporting on which disputes are rising in which districts.

9. Data / Resources Required

All data is synthetic. No real client records, no real case files, no live system integration — seeded fixtures only (fabricated clinics, schedules, paralegal accounts, case examples). Using real client data would be a serious breach given the intimacy of these narratives.

Technical options — teams choose, nothing is mandated:

Component	Options and trade-offs
Delivery channel	Progressive web app (fastest to demo) · WhatsApp voice notes (closest to real behaviour, needs API setup) · IVR phone call (widest real reach, heaviest telephony lift — may eat half the week)
Bangla ASR	Hosted cloud ASR (best accuracy, least effort, per-call cost) · self-hosted open multilingual model (control and offline capability, needs GPU and tuning)
Language model	Hosted frontier API (strongest Bangla comprehension) · smaller self-hosted model (cost control, weaker Bangla) · hybrid: model for extraction, templates for output — recommended
Bangla TTS	Hosted TTS · pre-recorded human audio for fixed explanatory content (arguably safer — a human voice reading reviewed content)
Supporting	Server-side PDF generation, any relational store, basic web hosting. The case-record schema matters more than the engine

Also needed: reviewed legal content per category from public sources; recorded test narratives from several native speakers across different accents.

Suggested team (4-5): AI/ML engineer (ASR, prompting, extraction, classification) · backend (schema, document generation, referral logic) · frontend (voice-first UI, dashboard, low-bandwidth behaviour) · **Bangla content and domain lead** (reviewed content, templates, tone, test narratives) · product/demo lead (scope discipline, scenario scripting). That fourth role matters more than it looks — a team without someone who writes natural, dignified Bangla will build something that works technically and fails the moment a real person speaks to it.

10. Success Criteria

Definition of done — this runs end to end, unassisted:

- ☐ User submits a narrative **by voice in Bangla** and gets a Bangla response
- ☐ Text fallback works for the same flow
- ☐ System classifies correctly, or asks a clarifying question when unsure

- ☐ Structured case summary generated: parties, timeline, claimed harm, category, evidence
- ☐ Draft complaint generated and downloadable, with unestablished facts left as placeholders
- ☐ Clinic referral produced with summary attached
- ☐ A safety disclosure visibly breaks the flow and escalates — demonstrated deliberately, not as an edge case
- ☐ Two full scenarios run start to finish (below)

Demo scenarios:

- **A — Dowry demand and unpaid dower.** A woman describes marrying four years ago, her husband's family demanding money from her father, her father selling land to pay part of it, the dower in her marriage contract never paid, and pressure now to leave the house. Expected: category identified with a dowry component; spoken explanation that dower is an enforceable claim; structured summary with parties, amounts, land sale, current pressure; draft complaint with placeholders; clinic referral.
- **B — Unpaid wages.** A worker describes three months unpaid from a small employer, no written contract, verbal promises of "next month," a supervisor who stopped taking calls. Expected: category identified; explanation of what can be claimed without a contract and what evidence helps; structured summary; draft complaint; referral.
- **C — Safety escalation.** Within one narrative, the user discloses ongoing physical violence. The system must visibly break out of the flow, surface human contact routes including the national helpline, and mark the case urgent.

Quality bar beyond the checklist: works on audio from **five different speakers**, not one rehearsed clip. Response under ~5 seconds with an audible "thinking" cue. Functional on a low-end Android handset and a weak connection. Graceful degradation — ASR failure falls back to text, model failure falls back to a direct clinic referral, never to an invented answer.

Main risks:

Risk	Mitigation
Bangla ASR weak on regional accents	Keep the text path fully working; record test audio in week one, not on the last day
Model hallucinates legal content	Hybrid approach — extract with the model, speak from reviewed templates
Scope creep into case law or outcome prediction	The out-of-scope table in §4 is binding; cut features rather than cross the line
Demo depends on one rehearsed clip	Test with at least five speakers
Week ends before anything runs end to end	Build the thin end-to-end path first, then deepen. A complete rough flow beats a polished fragment

Why Should You Build This?

This is a week where the hard problems are the interesting ones: Bangla speech recognition on real regional accents, pulling structured facts out of an emotional non-linear narrative, and building responsible-AI boundaries that actually hold under demo pressure. The demo is unforgettable — a woman speaks in Bangla for ninety seconds and a complete, structured case file comes out the other end. It sits on top of BRAC's own legal aid network, so the impact story is real rather than hypothetical, and the scope is honestly finishable: two scenarios, end to end, with a clear line around everything we're deliberately not building. If you want to spend the sprint on something a person could actually use, this is it.